

He made \$500,000 from Y Combinator

Channel: Arie Scherson · Published: Jun 16, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/shorts/FLIC6XNSVko> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

A former Amazon software development manager gave up a high six-figure salary to join Y Combinator, receiving \$500,000 in funding — now living off that investment and personal savings with zero salary.

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The Guest's Background [0:00](#)

- Was a **software development manager** leading engineering teams at Amazon
 - Was earning high six figures in that role
- Left that position to fly to San Francisco for what he called a "once-in-a-lifetime opportunity"
 - Goal: build a company through Y Combinator

The Y Combinator Opportunity [0:23](#)

- Framed his acceptance into YC as a once-in-a-lifetime chance
 - Interviewer acknowledges YC's track record: "a lot of incredible companies have come out of Y Combinator"
- YC is noted for producing many well-known, successful startups

The Equity Trade-Off [0:23](#)

- When asked about giving up equity, the guest was uncertain about the exact terms despite having signed the agreement
 - Interviewer finds this amusing: "You believe so. You signed it."
- Guest estimates **Y Combinator takes 7% of the company**
- He expressed no regret about giving up equity

- Cited benefits: connections and resources that come with YC membership

The Partners Debate 0:45

- Interviewer shares personal perspective on ownership vs. partnership
 - Notes he has partners in "pretty much" all his businesses
 - Acknowledges owning 100% feels good, but frames the trade-off as: "a smaller piece of a bigger pie"
 - A bigger team can build a bigger company, making partial ownership worthwhile
- Guest agrees with this framing and has no regrets about the partnership structure

The \$500,000 Deal & Current Survival 1:07

- Y Combinator's current funding amount: **\$500,000** per accepted company
 - Interviewer initially guessed ~\$175,000; corrected to half a million
- Guest's current financial situation:
 - Taking **zero salary**
 - Living off the \$500,000 initial YC investment and personal savings
 - Money is going toward basic costs — primarily rent

The guest walked away from high six-figure Amazon pay and is now surviving purely on YC's \$500K investment with no personal income, betting everything on his startup.